

EDUCATION

- California Institute of Technology** *Sep 2023 – Present*
○ Ph.D. student in Physics, Division of Physics, Mathematics and Astronomy (PMA)
○ Thesis advisor: Prof. Maria Spiropulu; research in machine learning and experimental high-energy physics
- University of California, San Diego** *Sep 2020 – June 2023*
○ Bachelor of Science in Physics and Computer Science, Phi Beta Kappa
- University of California, Santa Barbara** *Sep 2018 – Aug 2020*
○ Undergraduate study in Physics

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

- Caltech High Energy Physics Group | Graduate Research Assistant** *Sep 2023 – Present*
○ Advisor: Prof. Maria Spiropulu
○ Research at the Compact Muon Solenoid (CMS) Experiment at CERN and on deep learning methods for physics: self-supervised foundation models, neural-network tagger calibration, trigger development, and detector R&D
- Fermi National Accelerator Laboratory (Fermilab) | Visitor** *July – Nov 2024; July – Sep 2025*
○ Supervisor: Prof. Si Xie
○ Self-supervised learning methods for high-energy physics; search for double Higgs (HH) production with CMS data at the Large Hadron Collider
- UCSD Duarte Lab | Undergraduate Researcher** *Jan 2021 – June 2023*
○ Mentors: Prof. Javier Duarte and Dr. Raghav Kansal
○ Geometric deep learning for experimental high-energy physics: Lorentz-group-equivariant architectures, graph neural networks, and jet tagging

RESEARCH PROJECTS

- RINO: Renormalization Group Distillation with No Labels** *Nov 2024 – Present*
First author
○ Matched fully-supervised top tagging with $100\times$ fewer labels (accuracy 0.797 ± 0.015 finetuned on 1% of labels vs. 0.770 ± 0.026 supervised on 100%); improved out-of-distribution accuracy by 6.7% and AUC on unseen Higgs decay channels by 4.1% (relative, over the strongest baseline) without retraining
○ Pre-trained transformer encoders with DINO/DINOv2-style self-distillation (iBOT masked-token prediction, KoLeo regularization), using multi-scale k_T -clustering views as a physically grounded, renormalization-group-inspired source of self-supervised augmentations — ablations attribute an 11.4–14.0% improvement to the multi-scale views
○ Selected as a **spotlight** paper at the ML4PS workshop @ NeurIPS 2025 (offered to $\sim 1\%$ of accepted papers), [arXiv:2509.07486](#); full version under review at NeurIPS 2026
- Search for Non-Resonant HH Production in the $b\bar{b}b\bar{b}$ Final State** *Apr 2024 – Present*
Core contributor, CMS Collaboration
○ One of the main analyzers of the boosted $HH \rightarrow b\bar{b}b\bar{b}$ search, responsible for new BDT trainings, datacard creation, and the final statistical fits
○ Developing sensitivity improvements for the next analysis iteration, including a transformer-based approach and data-driven QCD background estimation
○ Performed calibration studies of transformer- and graph-based b-taggers (GloParT, ParticleNet), including data/simulation scale factors via the sFBDT method and $Z \rightarrow b\bar{b}$ control-region cross-checks
○ Measured trigger efficiencies and corrections for τ_3/τ_2 and tagger score distributions on $t\bar{t}$ MC samples; processed and managed data and simulation events for the calibration studies
○ Presented calibration results at the CMS B-Tagging and Vertexing (BTV) Working Group [\[link\]](#) and CMS Higgs Physics Group [\[link\]](#) meetings
○ Contributed to the public analysis [CMS-HIG-24-010](#) (submitted to *Phys. Rev. D*), which sets the most stringent limit on non-resonant HH production to date
- Development of the Barrel Timing Layer (BTL) at the CMS Experiment** *Oct 2023 – Present*
○ Contributed to the quality assurance and quality control (QA/QC) procedure
○ Assembled test modules and performed thermal cooling studies of the module

Search for Highly Energetic HH Production in the $b\bar{b}VV$ Final State

Mar – Apr 2024

- Optimized event selection based on signal and matching efficiencies; designed a new physics-inspired strategy for choosing signal events
- Analysis summary [CMS-PAS-HIG-23-012](#) made public

Development of Muon Detector Shower (MDS) Cross Triggers

Nov 2023 – Apr 2024

- Developed the electron+MDS and muon+MDS cross triggers, accepted into the CMS trigger menu in 2023; processed large datasets with parallel workflows

Lorentz Group Equivariant Jet Autoencoders (LGAE)

Jan 2021 – June 2023

First author; with Prof. Javier Duarte (UCSD), Dr. Raghav Kansal (UCSD, Fermilab), and Dr. Nadezda Chernyavskaya (CERN)

- Built an autoencoder fully equivariant to the Lorentz group, with a latent space in Lorentz-group irreducible representations, using equivariant message passing with Clebsch–Gordan tensor products
- Outperformed graph- and CNN-based autoencoder baselines on data compression, reconstruction, and unsupervised anomaly detection, with robust performance when trained on only 1% of data
- Published in *Eur. Phys. J. C* **83**, 485 (2023); ~35 citations

Development of the Tagger for $H \rightarrow WW^*$

June 2021 – Jan 2022

Supported by the UCSD Undergraduate Summer Research Award; with Prof. Javier Duarte (UCSD), Dr. Raghav Kansal (UCSD, Fermilab), Dr. Cristina Mantilla Suarez (Fermilab), and Prof. Si Xie (Caltech)

- Developed a neural-network tagger for $H \rightarrow WW^*$ decays against QCD backgrounds on the ParticleNet architecture ([arXiv:1902.08570](#)) for the CMS experiment

TEACHING

Caltech Ph 22 (Computational Physics Laboratory III) | Teaching Assistant

Mar – Jun 2026

- Led lab sessions, graded coursework, and taught core AI concepts
- One of two TAs who designed the course's final project — reinforcement learning for quantum state preparation: built the Gymnasium environment over a Tavis–Cummings cavity-QED simulator, the REINFORCE reference implementation, PPO/SAC/TQC baselines (Stable-Baselines3) with MLP/LSTM/Transformer policies and multi-seed evaluation, reward shaping, and the project questions

PUBLICATIONS

- [Zichun Hao](#), Raghav Kansal, Abhijith Gandrakota, Chang Sun, Jennifer Ngadiuba, Javier Duarte, Maria Spiropulu, “RINO: Renormalization Group Invariance with No Labels,” Nov. 2025, [arXiv:2509.07486](#) (ML4PS workshop [spotlight paper](#), offered to ~1% of accepted papers; [poster](#)). Full version, retitled “RINO: Renormalization Group Distillation with No Labels,” under review at NeurIPS 2026
- Michael Chen, Raghav Kansal, Abhijith Gandrakota, [Zichun Hao](#), Jennifer Ngadiuba, Maria Spiropulu, “An Evaluation of Representation Learning Methods in Particle Physics Foundation Models,” Nov. 2025, [arXiv:2511.12829](#) (ML4PS [paper](#); [poster](#)) — served as a mentor on this work
- Raghav Kansal, Carlos Pareja, [Zichun Hao](#), Javier Duarte, “JetNet: A Python Package for Accessing Open Datasets and Benchmarking Machine Learning Methods in High Energy Physics,” *J. Open Source Softw.* **8**(90), 5789 (2023), doi:[10.21105/joss.05789](#)
- [Zichun Hao](#), Raghav Kansal, Javier Duarte, Nadezda Chernyavskaya, “Lorentz Group Equivariant Autoencoders,” *Eur. Phys. J. C* **83**, 485 (2023), doi:[10.1140/epjc/s10052-023-11633-5](#)
- CMS Collaboration, “Improved results on Higgs boson pair production in the $4b$ final state,” 2026, [arXiv:2604.27044](#), submitted to *Phys. Rev. D* — core contributor
- CMS Collaboration, “Search for highly energetic double Higgs boson production in the two bottom quark and two vector boson all-hadronic final state,” [CMS-PAS-HIG-23-012](#), CERN (2024) — contributor

CONFERENCES & WORKSHOPS

- Spotlight talk at the ML4PS workshop, 39th Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS 2025), on RINO
- [ML4Jets 2025](#) on RINO and on representation learning of jets with physics-informed self-distillation
- [APS Global Physics Summit 2025](#) on neural-network tagger calibrations in the search for nonresonant Higgs boson pair production in the four b-quark decay channel with Run-3 CMS data (Mar. 20, 2025)
- [ML4Jets 2024](#) on Lorentz group equivariant jet autoencoders (Nov. 2024)
- [APS Far West Section Annual Meeting 2023](#) on Lorentz group equivariant jet autoencoders (Oct. 7, 2023)
- [APS April Meeting 2022](#) on the $H \rightarrow WW^*$ tagger (Apr. 9–12, 2022)
- [ML4Jets 2021](#) on Lorentz group equivariant jet autoencoders (July 6, 2021)
- [UCSD Online Undergraduate Research Symposium 2021](#) on Lorentz group equivariant jet autoencoders (May 26, 2021)

HONORS & AWARDS

- **Spotlight** paper (first author), ML4PS workshop @ NeurIPS 2025 — offered to ~1% of the workshop's accepted papers
- Fermilab LPC Guest and Visitor Award (2024 & 2025)
- [Phi Beta Kappa Honor Society](#) (Apr. 2022)
- UCSD Physical Sciences [2022 Dean's Undergraduate Award for Excellence](#)
- UCSD [2021 Undergraduate Summer Research Award](#)
- UCSD Provost Honors (Fall 2020, Winter 2021, Spring 2021, Fall 2021, Winter 2022, Spring 2022)
- UCSB Dean's Honors (Winter 2019, Spring 2019, Fall 2019, Winter 2020, Spring 2020)